It Really Happened

A Thought on Parashat Vayera

Dvar Torah - a printable page



Dear children, in Parashat Vayera the Torah tells us about the overturning of Sodom and Amorah. The people of Sodom and Amorah were very wicked, and Hashem had to punish them and turn their cities into a wasteland. After Hashem tells Avraham that Sodom will be destroyed, Avraham Avinu asks Hashem to have mercy on the whole city if fifty righteous people are found there. After Hashem agrees to his request, he goes on to ask for forty-five righteous people too. From there he goes down to forty, and so on, until he reaches just ten righteous people. But why does Avraham Avinu need to start with fifty? Why doesn't he ask Hashem right from the start to have mercy on the whole city for the sake of just ten righteous people?

The answer is that Avraham Avinu taught us how to reach things that seem impossible to us. When Avraham Avinu asks Hashem to have mercy on the whole city for the sake of ten righteous people, he has to believe that it's possible, because if he himself doesn't believe it's possible, Hashem won't agree to it either. That's why he starts by asking for fifty righteous people, something that seems reasonable. After Hashem agrees to his request, his faith grows stronger, and it's already easier to reach further. And so, little by little, Avraham Avinu keeps going down until he reaches ten righteous people.

Avraham Avinu teaches us that to succeed in going far, we first have to keep working at it, steadily and patiently, until the thing we're reaching for becomes possible in our own minds. Only then can we pray for it properly and come closer to making the dream come true.

Shabbat Shalom, and a blessed one!